

CAMBIUM ACADEMY • COURSE 02

Prompting Essentials

How to ask. When to trust.



Free • No signup • Certificate included

July 2026 edition. The AI world moves fast, so facts carry dates. Free forever.

WELCOME

Built for beginners, on purpose

◆ **No code. No jargon. No experience needed.**

If you can type a question, you are qualified.

◆ **A browser, about 90 minutes, and \$0**

That is the whole entry fee. No account, no email.

◆ **Use the chatbot you already have open**

Nothing new to install or sign up for.

WORKS WITH

◆ ChatGPT

◆ Claude

◆ Gemini

or any chatbot you already use

OUTCOMES

What you'll be able to do

- ◆ Write an ask that works on the first try
- ◆ Get honest answers, not confident guesses
- ◆ Pick instant vs thinking mode on purpose
- ◆ Give the AI your material, and manage its memory
- ◆ Control tone by showing, not describing
- ◆ Verify any answer in under a minute

Five steps to your certificate

1

Watch the lecture

6 modules, ~20 min

2

**Clear the
flashcards**

24 quick cards

3

Try the AI Lab

3 hands-on stations

4

Pass the quiz

20 questions, 14 to pass

5

Get the certificate

Prints instantly

MODULE 1

Why answers vary so much

Same AI, wildly different results. Here is the real reason.



The era of magic words is over

2023

- ◆ Collect magic phrases
- ◆ "100 prompts that unlock AI!"
- ◆ Brittle models, secret words

2026

- ◆ Models understand plain language
- ◆ The treasure hunt is over
- ◆ Ordinary words work fine

WHAT STILL MOVES THE NEEDLE: STRUCTURE AND CONTEXT

Not wording tricks. Briefing quality.

Meet your intern

◆ A brilliant intern

Has read nearly everything ever published. Fast, tireless, eager.

◆ But it is their first day

It knows nothing about you, your project, or your standards.

◆ Every new chat is another first day

Unless you use memory (Module 5), it starts fresh each time.

Great briefing in, great work out.

Every chatbot now has two speeds

INSTANT

- ◆ Answers in seconds
- ◆ Everyday questions
- ◆ Quick facts, rewrites, chat

THINKING

- ◆ Works longer before answering
- ◆ Hard problems
- ◆ Math, planning, tricky logic

WHERE TO FIND IT (NAMES SHIFT MONTHLY, THE TWO SPEEDS STAY)

ChatGPT: Instant / Thinking · Claude: adapts automatically · Gemini: thinking levels

Match the speed to the job

STAY INSTANT FOR

- ◆ Quick facts
- ◆ Rewrites
- ◆ Brainstorms
- ◆ Casual questions

GO THINKING FOR

- ◆ Math
- ◆ Planning
- ◆ Comparing options
- ◆ Anything to double-check

If you'd give a colleague 10 quiet minutes for it, give the AI thinking mode.

MODULE 2

The anatomy of a great ask

Task. Context. Format. And the famous tip you should drop.



PART ONE: TASK

Give it a job, not a topic

A topic is not a task. A search box takes topics; the intern needs a job.

BEFORE

Marketing plan for a bakery

AFTER

Write a one-page marketing plan for a new neighborhood bakery targeting families within 2 miles, budget under \$500 a month

The recipe: verb + deliverable + audience + limits.

PART TWO: CONTEXT

Tell it what it can't know

Who is it for? What's the situation? What have you tried? What does good look like?

BEFORE

Write a birthday message

AFTER

Write a short birthday message for my dad turning 70: retired teacher, dry humor, we joke about his terrible golf swing

Say what the answer should look like

No format request means a bullet-heavy "AI voice" by default.

BEFORE

Summarize this article

AFTER

Summarize this article in three plain sentences, no bullet points, for someone who hasn't read it

Name the length, the structure, and the tone.

THE WHOLE RECIPE

Say it, brief it, shape it

TASK

what to make

CONTEXT

what it can't guess

FORMAT

what it looks like

EXAMPLE PROMPT

Write a one-page marketing plan **[TASK]** for my new bakery near two schools, families are the customers, \$500/month budget, opening in September **[CONTEXT]**. Four sections: Audience, Channels, 30-day calendar, Budget **[FORMAT]**.

Brief it like you'd brief a person. No secret phrase required.

THE FAMOUS TIP TO DROP

"Act as a world-class expert"

2026 research: personas make answers SOUND smarter, not BE smarter.

BROAD KNOWLEDGE TEST

~72% to ~68%

Accuracy dropped the moment an expert persona was added.

SO WHERE DOES IT LAND?

◆ **Helps:** tone, style, audience fit

◆ **Hurts:** facts, math, precise recall

Sounding expert competes with being accurate.

THE HONEST RULE

When a role helps, and when to skip it

USE FOR VOICE

"Explain this like a patient math tutor for a nervous adult."

SKIP FOR FACTS

You are a world-renowned tax expert. What's the deduction limit for X?

ASK PLAINLY INSTEAD

What's the current deduction limit for X? If this may have changed recently, say so and tell me where to verify.

MODULE 3

Show, don't describe

The fastest way to control tone and shape: give one example.



THE DIAGNOSIS

Why everything sounds like AI

◆ **No sample given, so the model averages the whole internet**

And the average of the internet is that beige, over-enthusiastic voice.

YOU KNOW THE TELLS

Delve

Dive in

Game-changer

"I hope this finds you well"

The fix isn't a better adjective. It's a sample.

SHOW THE VOICE

Paste the tone you want

THE MOVE

"Here's an email I wrote that sounds like me: [paste it]. Now write the new one in the same voice."

◆ **One to three samples is plenty**

One good sample usually transforms the output; a couple lock it in.

◆ **Keep your samples consistent**

The model copies the pattern it sees, formatting included.

SHOW THE SHAPE

Order the exact shape

Describing the shape works. Showing the shape works better.

NAME THE COLUMNS

"Compare these 3 phones in a table: columns Price, Battery, Camera, one row each, then a one-sentence verdict."

OR SKETCH ONE LINE OF IT

Format each item like: **NAME (year) · one-line why**

A tiny sketch beats a paragraph. The model completes patterns for a living.

MODULE 4

Steering, and second drafts

Four habits that separate people who get value from people who get words.



HABIT ONE

The pink elephant problem

"Don't think of a pink elephant." You just did. Naming what to avoid keeps it in play.

BEFORE

Don't be formal.

AFTER

Write like you'd text a friendly coworker.

The rule: pair every DON'T with a DO, so the model always has somewhere to go.

HABIT TWO

Give it an out

Models are trained to be helpful and fluent. Silence feels like failure to them.

ADD ONE LINE, VERBATIM

"If you're not fully sure, say so, and tell me what you'd check."

Uncertain-but-honest beats confident-but-wrong. Every time.

HABIT THREE

"Think step by step" is now a sometimes-tool

ON THINKING MODELS

- ◆ Already reason privately
- ◆ Adds 20 to 80% more time
- ◆ Little or no accuracy gain

ON INSTANT MODELS

- ◆ Helps modestly on multi-step
- ◆ Adds variability
- ◆ Can even break easy questions

Ask for steps when the TASK has steps (a plan, a checklist). Don't chant at a model that's already thinking.

HABIT FOUR

Never ship the first draft

The first answer is a first draft, not a verdict. It's a conversation, not a slot machine.

◆ "What's weak about this? Fix it."

◆ "Give me 3 versions: safe, bold, unexpected."

◆ "Ask me 3 questions before you answer."

One more pull of the lever is not failure. It is the technique.

SCREENSHOT THIS

The pocket toolkit

1

Give it a job, not a topic

2

Brief it like a person: context it can't guess

3

Show a sample of the tone or shape

4

Say what you want, not just what to avoid

5

"If you're not fully sure, say so, and tell me what you'd check."

6

Then: "What's weak about this? Fix it."

MODULE 5

Your material, and its memory

What the model can SEE decides what it can do. Hand over the folder.



CLEAR UP THE CONFUSION

Open book, not training

◆ **Uploading a file gives an open-book reference for your chats**

It reads your file the way you'd read a handout, for this conversation.

◆ **It does NOT retrain the AI**

Your file doesn't teach the public model or join a shared pool.

◆ **So uploading beats summarizing by hand**

The model quotes your actual material instead of guessing.

Training on your chats is a separate privacy setting, and worth checking once.

A ROOM FOR YOUR STUFF

The three rooms

Claude Projects

Files plus standing instructions, shared by every chat inside.

ChatGPT Projects

Same idea. Custom GPTs go further: a packaged assistant you can share.

Gemini Gems

Can live-sync Google Drive files, so the reference stays current.

Names and limits shift. The concept doesn't: a room where your material lives.

First or last, never buried

Models read long material unevenly. Researchers call it "lost in the middle."

START

strong

MIDDLE

weak

END

strong

◆ **Put the key document or instruction first or last**

Never sandwiched in the middle of a giant paste.

◆ **Pasting a lot? Say where to look**

"Focus on section 4," or, "the part I care about is the pricing table."

IT KEEPS NOTES ON YOU

It remembers you now

In 2026, all three remember things about you across chats. You can read, edit, and delete it.

ChatGPT

Settings › Personalization ›
Memory

Claude

Settings › Memory

Gemini

"Saved info" page

Want a conversation to leave no trace? Use the temporary or incognito chat mode.

MODULE 6

When to trust the answer

The skill that makes all the others safe to use.



THE UNCOMFORTABLE FACT

Confidence is not accuracy

Wrong answers arrive in the same confident tone as right ones. The tone never wobbles.

HALLUCINATION RATE, 26 TOP MODELS

22% to **94%**

On one benchmark (Stanford 2026 AI Index). It depends on model and task.

SO WHAT DO YOU USE INSTEAD?

Don't use confidence as your signal. Use **cost**.

- ◆ Costs nothing? Enjoy the answer.
- ◆ Costs money, health, a grade, or reputation? Verify.

THE SIXTY-SECOND CHECK

Lateral reading

Don't ask the AI to grade its own homework. It'll do so politely, and tell you nothing.

1

Open a new tab

Leave the chat

2

Search the specific claim

The number, name, or date

3

Find one independent source

See if it agrees

◆ When it gives you sources, actually open one

In 2026 links are usually real; the question is whether the page says what the summary claims.

Verify the claim, not the vibe.

Don't lead the witness

Models tend to agree with what YOU signal you believe. Researchers call it sycophancy.

SAME FALSE CLAIM, TWO FRAMINGS

◆ "Someone says X" model corrects it

◆ "I believe X" accuracy collapses

One reported example: **~98% to ~64%** on the same claims.

HOW TO ASK INSTEAD

◆ Ask neutral: "Is X true?" not "X is true, right?"

◆ Power move for decisions: "**Argue against my plan.**"

Hidden instructions are real

Anything pasted into a chat can act as an instruction, not just as information.

A REAL 2026 CASE

A shared claude.ai link secretly pre-filled invisible instructions; one Enter press could leak chat history (now fixed).

- ◆ **Don't run "paste this prompt!" links from strangers**
- ◆ **Skim big pastes before you feed them**
- ◆ **If the answer goes weird after a paste, suspect the paste**

KNOW THE ROOM

Say when AI helped

Disclosure has no single rule. It has rooms.

AT SCHOOL

- ◆ The syllabus decides
- ◆ Often per assignment
- ◆ Ask if it's unclear, don't guess

AT WORK

- ◆ You own what you ship
- ◆ Review before your name goes on it
- ◆ Many teams now ask for a heads-up

Know the rules of the room you're in, and when in doubt, say so.

The habits that compound

ASK

job not topic · brief like a person · show a sample · name the shape

STEER

say what you want · give it an out · pick the right speed · never ship draft one

TRUST

verify by cost · read laterally · don't lead the witness · watch your pastes

Technique gets you good answers. **Judgment makes them safe to use.**

KEEP LEARNING

Free and hand-verified this month

◆ **Anthropic** Prompting guide + prompt library

◆ **OpenAI** Prompt engineering guide

◆ **Google** Gemini prompting strategies

◆ **Learn Prompting** Gentle full beginner course

◆ **Anthropic tutorial** Interactive, hands-on exercises

Full annotated list, with what each one is best for, on the course resources page.

THAT'S THE LECTURE



Two steps to unlock the quiz

- ◆ Clear the 24 flashcards
- ◆ Try the 3 AI Lab stations
- ◆ Quiz: 20 questions, 14 to pass, certificate prints instantly

New Cambium Academy course lands next week. I'll see you there.